

Title

Designing an Enhanced Recovery After Surgery-informed nutritional support strategy for intensive care: protocol for a randomized comparative effectiveness study

Abstract

Objective: To develop and evaluate a systematic approach to nutritional management in critically ill patients drawing on principles from the Enhanced Recovery After Surgery (ERAS) framework. **Methods:** This randomized comparative effectiveness trial will enroll 100 critically ill patients from intensive care units. Participants will be assigned to receive either the ERAS-informed nutrition protocol or conventional nutritional management. The ERAS-informed approach incorporates optimized nutrient delivery schedules, systematic assessment of gastrointestinal function, and evidence-based monitoring of nutritional indices. Primary endpoints include total caloric and protein delivery within the first week of care. Secondary endpoints encompass laboratory markers of nutritional status, gastrointestinal complications, and length of intensive care stay. Blinding is not feasible given the nature of nutritional interventions. This study addresses the gap in systematic implementation of recovery-focused nutrition in the ICU setting.